STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

WAREHOUSE DRUM HANDLING & CHEMICAL HANDLING | SOP TEMPLATE

SOP ID: WHS-CH-001	**Version:** 1.0	**Effective date:** _____	**Approved by:** _____

1. Purpose and scope

Set minimum safe practices for receiving, moving, storing and handling drums and packaged chemicals. Applies to warehouse staff, contractors and drivers in designated areas. Follow the site risk assessment, product label and current Safety Data Sheet (SDS) whenever they specify stricter controls.

2. Roles and responsibilities

- **Supervisor:** ensure training, suitable equipment, segregated storage, spill supplies and emergency arrangements.
- **Authorized handlers:** inspect containers, use approved equipment and PPE, follow labels/SDS, and report hazards.
- **Everyone:** do not handle unknown, leaking, bulging, corroded or damaged containers; isolate the area and notify the supervisor.

3. Before handling — mandatory checks

- Confirm product identity, hazard pictograms, container condition, quantity and destination against receiving documents.
- Read the SDS before first handling. Check PPE, incompatibilities, storage conditions, ventilation, first aid and spill response.
- Inspect route and floor; keep aisles clear, dry and level. Confirm ramps, lifts and racks can accommodate the load.
- Inspect the drum trolley, drum grabber, pallet truck or forklift attachment. Never improvise lifting points or use damaged equipment.
- Wear task-specific PPE from the SDS/risk assessment: safety footwear, suitable gloves and eye/face protection; add apron or respiratory protection when required and authorized.

4. Drum handling procedure

- Use mechanical aids wherever possible. Check drum weight and stability; do not manually lift or roll drums beyond the site-approved method and limits.
- Secure drums upright on compatible pallets or in drum cradles. Use a rated drum clamp/attachment and keep loads low while travelling.
- Move slowly; avoid sudden turns, impacts, dragging, dropping or rolling drums down ramps. Keep hands and feet clear of pinch points.
- Never stand or walk beneath a raised load. Keep people clear of the travel path and never exceed equipment or rack capacity.
- For a leaking or damaged drum: stop work, warn others, restrict access and follow the spill/emergency procedure. Move it only if trained, equipped and authorized.

5. Storage and housekeeping

- Store containers closed, upright, labelled and protected from impact and weather. Use stable, compatible pallets and suitable secondary containment.
- Segregate incompatible chemicals according to SDS/site rules. For example, keep acids away from alkalis and oxidizers away from flammables where required by compatibility guidance.
- Keep exits, eyewash/showers, extinguishers and spill kits accessible. Maintain required ventilation and ignition controls.
- Inspect storage areas routinely. Record leaks, damage, inventory discrepancies and corrective actions; clean only by approved methods.

CHEMICAL HANDLING, SPILLS & EMERGENCIES

6. Safe chemical handling

- Handle only chemicals you are trained and authorized to use. Verify the label before use; never rely on container colour or memory.
- Use designated, compatible transfer tools and containers. Keep lids closed when not dispensing; never use food or drink containers for chemicals.
- Do not mix chemicals unless an approved written procedure specifically requires it. Never combine unknown residues or return unused material to the original container.
- Avoid inhalation, splashes and skin contact. Do not eat, drink or smoke in handling areas. Wash hands after handling and before breaks.
- For decanting, use required ventilation, bonding/grounding and ignition controls where specified by the SDS/risk assessment. Label secondary containers with product identity and hazards.
- Dispose of residues, contaminated absorbents and empty containers through the approved waste process. Do not pour chemicals into drains unless expressly authorized.

7. Spill, exposure and emergency response

Situation	Immediate action
Small spill — only if trained, material is known and within site response limits.	Warn nearby staff, isolate the area, consult the SDS/spill plan, wear specified PPE, and use a compatible spill kit only if safe. Collect waste in a compatible, labelled container and report/document the event.
Large, unknown, volatile, highly toxic, reactive or fire-related release	Do not attempt cleanup. Raise the alarm, evacuate by the designated route, keep others out and contact the site emergency team. Follow the posted emergency plan; do not re-enter until authorized.
Skin/eye contact or inhalation	Follow SDS first-aid instructions. Use the designated eyewash/shower immediately when indicated; remove contaminated clothing if safe. Seek medical help and provide product/SDS details. Do not enter a contaminated area to rescue someone without proper training and equipment.

EMERGENCY RULE: Protect people first. Do not touch, smell or attempt to identify an unknown spill. Raise the alarm and follow the site emergency plan.

8. Prohibited actions

- No handling without training, required PPE or suitable equipment; no damaged lifting attachments or overloaded pallets/racks.
- No smoking/open flames near flammables; no unauthorized chemical mixing, relabelling, draining or disposal.
- No cleanup of unknown or beyond-capability spills; no re-entry until the responsible site authority declares the area safe.

9. Records, training and sign-off

- Maintain training records, equipment inspections, chemical inventory/SDS access, storage inspections, spill/near-miss reports and corrective-action records.
- Review after an incident, chemical/process change, new equipment or change in applicable requirements. Brief affected staff and verify understanding.

Prepared by: _____	**Reviewed by:** _____	**Approved by:** _____
Date: _____	**Briefing date:** _____	**Next review:** _____

Important: General template only. Before operational use, have the responsible EHS/safety professional adapt it to the site risk assessment, local legal requirements, each chemical's SDS and the emergency response plan.